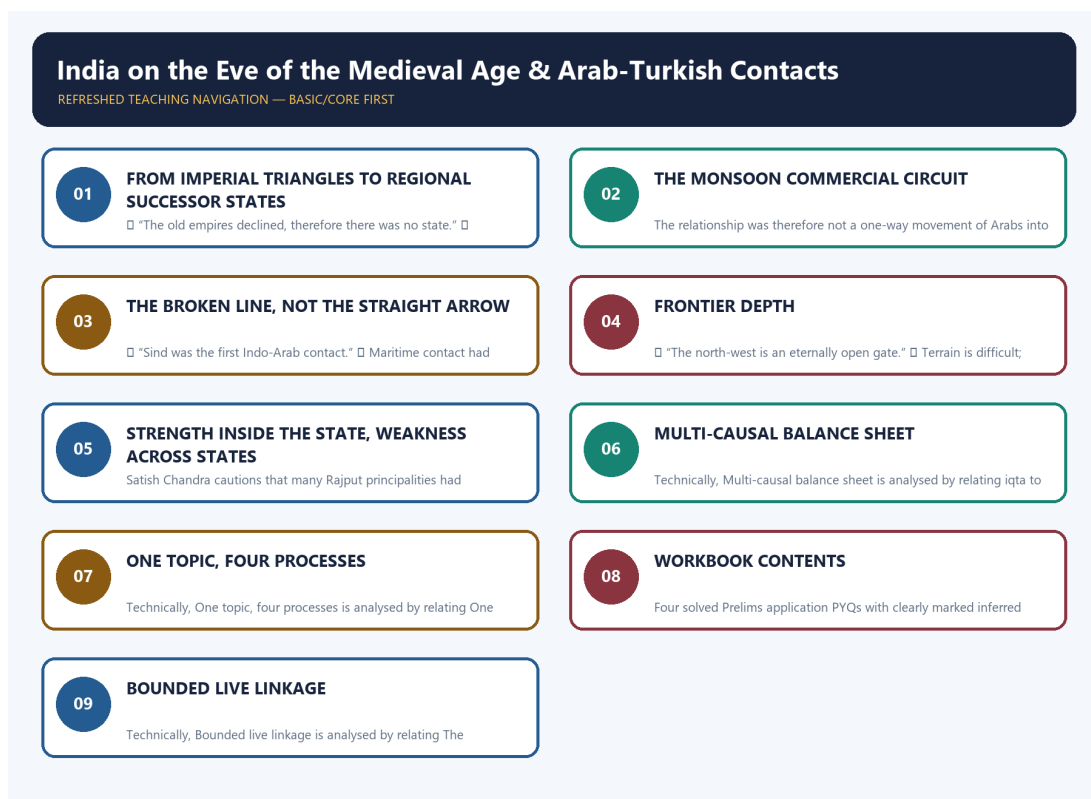


SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

India on the Eve of the Medieval Age & Arab-Turkish Contacts - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing



Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

CONTENTS / WORKBOOK INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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India on the Eve of the Medieval Age & Arab-Turkish Contacts - Solved Practice Workbook

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Learning MCQ 01

Which statement best describes north India on the eve of Turkish political expansion?

- A. A regionalised political order containing substantial but fragmented centres of power
- B. A unified Rajput confederacy under the Chauhans
- C. A region without organised states after the disappearance of the Pratiharas
- D. A commercial system disconnected from West Asia

Answer: A. - The central distinction is between absence of capacity and fragmentation of capacity.

Learning MCQ 02

The decline of the Palas, Pratiharas and Rashtrakutas is best understood as:

- A. the replacement of all agrarian institutions
- B. a transition towards regional successor polities
- C. the end of Indian Ocean commerce
- D. the immediate beginning of the Delhi Sultanate

Answer: B. - Neither economy nor institutions vanished automatically with dynastic decline.

--- PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST ----- BOOK: Book context: queried - Satish Chandra, *History of Medieval India*, local PDF pp. 18 and 22; Part I, p. 8. SEARCH: CA Search: "India current affairs 2026 medieval maritime heritage Arab trade Malabar Muziris Pattanam archaeology" CURRENT: CA Found: First International Spice Routes Conference, Kochi, 6-8 January 2026, official Kerala Tourism page. -----

Learning MCQ 03

With reference to Arab maritime activity before the Delhi Sultanate, consider the following statements:

1. Arab traders displaced Indian traders from the Persian Gulf trade.
2. Arab merchant settlements existed on the Malabar coast.
3. Some Indian rulers permitted Muslim merchants to build mosques.

Which of the statements given above are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 1, 2 and 3
- C. 2 and 3 only
- D. 1 and 3 only

Answer: C. - Statement 1 reverses Satish Chandra's explicit point.

Learning MCQ 04

The term “commercial diaspora” is most useful here because it captures:

- A. the disappearance of religious identity in ports
- B. the replacement of Indian rulers by merchant councils
- C. the complete separation of ports from their hinterlands
- D. merchants retaining long-distance ties while developing local institutions

Answer: D. -

--- PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST ----- BOOK: Book context: queried - Satish Chandra's distinction between the eighth-century Sind episode and the later Ghaznavid-Ghurid sequence. SEARCH: CA Search: "India 2026 Sind Debal Banbhore archaeological heritage Arab conquest inscription" CURRENT: CA Found: no sufficiently reliable India-specific official development in the last six months. Banbhore/Debal remains a useful archaeological comparison, but identification claims require caution. -----

Learning MCQ 05

Which conclusion is most defensible regarding the Arab conquest of Sind?

- A. It created a regional political foothold and a channel of cultural exchange without directly causing the later Sultanate.
- B. It ended Indian merchant activity in the Arabian Sea.
- C. It introduced Persian culture to Central Asian Turks.
- D. It immediately established a north Indian sultanate.

Answer: A. -

Learning MCQ 06

An excavated port is identified with a port named in a medieval text. Which additional evidence most strengthens the identification?

- A. A later legend alone
- B. Convergent chronology, geography, stratigraphy and inscriptional evidence
- C. The modern popularity of the identification
- D. Similarity of one artefact to an object found elsewhere

Answer: B. -

--- PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST ----- BOOK: Book context: queried - Satish Chandra, Part I, local PDF pp. 8-10; *History of Medieval India*, p. 70. SEARCH: CA Search: "India 2026 Persian manuscripts digitisation medieval history Ministry of Culture" CURRENT: CA Found: Gyan Bharatam mission and the 31 July 2026 National Digitisation Drive workshop; relevant to Persian and Arabic manuscript accessibility, but not evidence for tenth-century events. -----

Learning MCQ 07

The description of the early Turkish rulers as “Persianised” primarily refers to their:

- A. biological descent from Iranian dynasties
- B. rejection of Islamic legitimacy
- C. adoption of Persian language, court culture and administrative practices
- D. abandonment of military organisation

Answer: C. -

Learning MCQ 08

Which sequence best explains the rise of Ghazni?

- A. Ghurid conquest of Delhi -> establishment of Ghazni
- B. Chola decline -> Arab conquest of Baghdad -> Ghaznavid rule
- C. Stronger Abbasid centralisation -> decline of commanders -> rise of Indian merchants
- D. Abbasid fragmentation -> regional military competition -> autonomous Turkish commanders

Answer: D. -

--- PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST ----- BOOK: Book context: queried - Satish Chandra, Part I, local PDF pp. 9-10, especially the phrase "outer bastions" and road communications. SEARCH: CA Search: "2026 India Afghanistan historical routes Kabul Jalalabad heritage current affairs" CURRENT: CA Found: no credible topic-specific development in the last six months. The linkage remains conceptual: routes, strategic depth and frontier control.

Learning MCQ 09

In the present context, the "outer bastions" thesis is best understood as:

- A. strategic depth provided by frontier zones and communication routes
- B. a claim that conquest became inevitable in the eighth century
- C. a religious boundary separating two civilisations
- D. proof that north India had no organised defence

Answer: A. -

Learning MCQ 10

Improved road communications between Ghazni, Kabul and Jalalabad most directly enhanced:

- A. the ritual authority of Indian kings
- B. cavalry movement, supply and reinforcement
- C. monsoon maritime trade
- D. hereditary ownership under the iqta system

Answer: B. -

--- PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST ----- BOOK: Book context: queried - Satish Chandra, *History of Medieval India*, pp. 55-57 and 69-70; Part I, pp. 10-16. SEARCH: CA Search: "2026 Rajput medieval inscription heritage India current affairs" CURRENT: CA Found: no credible directly linked development in the last six months. Gyan Bharatam remains a source-preservation anchor, not a factual update on Rajput polity. -----

Learning MCQ 11

Which explanation best captures the political limitation of the Rajput order?

- A. Lack of agrarian revenue
- B. Complete absence of fortified centres
- C. Difficulty converting multiple substantial regional powers into durable unified command
- D. Inability to raise any cavalry

Answer: C. -

Learning MCQ 12

The concept of "Rajputisation" most directly highlights:

- A. the disappearance of Brahmanical legitimisation
- B. an unchanging racial category
- C. the replacement of all cultivators by warriors
- D. the interaction of agrarian expansion, political power and status formation

Answer: D. -

--- PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST ----- BOOK: Book context: queried - Satish Chandra's structural explanation in Part I, pp. 14-16, read with the authored advanced file. SEARCH: CA Search: "2026 military logistics historical routes India heritage cavalry technology medieval" CURRENT: CA Found: none directly linked in the last six months. No decorative defence-current-affairs analogy is forced into a historical explanation. -----

Learning MCQ 13

Which statement about iqta is most appropriate for this topic?

- A. It was a revenue assignment associated with military maintenance and ruler-controlled service.
- B. It originated in the Rajput clan system.
- C. It was unrestricted hereditary ownership of land and cultivators.
- D. It abolished the need for cavalry.

Answer: A. -

Learning MCQ 14

The First Battle of Tarain is analytically important because it:

- A. ended Ghaznavid control over Punjab
- B. demonstrates that later Turkish victory was contingent rather than inevitable
- C. established the Delhi Sultanate in 1191
- D. proves that cavalry had no military value

Answer: B. -

--- PRE-TEACH CHECKLIST ----- BOOK: Book context: queried - both Satish Chandra narratives and both mandatory Markdown files co-related. SEARCH: CA Search: "2026 India medieval maritime heritage manuscripts digitisation UPSC history" CURRENT: CA Found: International Spice Routes Conference, January 2026; Gyan Bharatam National Digitisation Drive workshop, July 2026. -----

Learning MCQ 15

Which pairing is most accurate?

- A. Persianisation - ethnic replacement of Turks by Iranians
- B. Arab maritime contact - necessarily territorial sovereignty
- C. Outer bastions - strategic depth and frontier communications
- D. Rajput regionalisation - absence of state capacity

Answer: C. -

Learning MCQ 16

Which conclusion best synthesises the topic?

- A. Turkish conquest was inevitable after the Arab conquest of Sind.
- B. Weapon technology alone explains the political transition.
- C. Indian Ocean trade ended before Turkish expansion.
- D. A combination of frontier change, concentrated military organisation, regional rivalry and contingent decisions shifted the balance.

Answer: D. -

Workbook MCQ 01

Which formulation most accurately distinguishes Arab maritime contact from later Turkish political expansion?

- A. The former was primarily a long-duration commercial-cultural process; the latter increasingly involved frontier bases and territorial warfare.
- B. The former eliminated Indian merchants before the latter began.
- C. The former began only after the establishment of the Delhi Sultanate.
- D. Both were identical movements led by the same institutions.

Answer: A. - The subject's master distinction is between overlapping but non-identical processes. Arab merchant activity long preceded 1206.

Workbook MCQ 02

Which political power is specifically associated in the source material with welcoming Arab traders and permitting mosques?

- A. Gahadavalas
- B. Rashtrakutas
- C. Tomaras
- D. Hindu Shahis

Answer: B. - This is evidence of commercial accommodation, not Arab sovereignty over the Rashtrakuta state.

Workbook MCQ 03

The most defensible description of the historical significance of the Arab conquest of Sind is:

- A. complete replacement of Indian Ocean merchants
- B. immediate establishment of the Delhi Sultanate
- C. a regional political foothold and conduit of knowledge exchange separated by centuries from the Sultanate
- D. origin of the Samanid state

Answer: C. -

Workbook MCQ 04

Turkish military elites entering the Indian frontier were:

- A. untouched by Iranian culture
- B. Persian-speaking but non-Islamic
- C. culturally identical to the Abbasid caliphs
- D. Islamised and substantially Persianised

Answer: D. - "Turkish", "Islamic" and "Persianate" describe different, intersecting dimensions.

Workbook MCQ 05

Who established himself as an independent ruler at Ghazni in 963?

- A. Alp-tigin
- B. Firdausi
- C. Muizzuddin Muhammad
- D. Jayapala

Answer: A. -

Workbook MCQ 06

The expression "outer bastions" in Satish Chandra is best read as:

- A. a fixed modern national border
- B. strategic depth formed by frontier zones such as Zabulistan and Afghanistan
- C. a religious boundary unaffected by roads
- D. evidence that Delhi's fall was immediate

Answer: B. -

Workbook MCQ 07

Which statement best describes the Rajput political order?

- A. It lacked all agrarian and military resources.
- B. It was organised through the iqta system.
- C. It contained substantial regional powers whose rivalry complicated durable coordination.
- D. It maintained permanent unified command across north India.

Answer: C. -

Workbook MCQ 08

Which statement regarding iqta is least inaccurate?

- A. It abolished military-service obligations.
- B. It was necessarily hereditary and outside ruler control.
- C. It was unrestricted private ownership of cultivators.
- D. It was a revenue assignment linked to service and troop maintenance.

Answer: D. -

Workbook MCQ 09

Arrange the following in chronological order:

1. Alp-tigin establishes himself at Ghazni.
 2. Muizzuddin takes Ghazni.
 3. First Battle of Tarain.
 4. Arab conquest of Sind.
- A. 4-1-2-3
 - B. 4-2-1-3
 - C. 1-4-2-3
 - D. 1-2-4-3

Answer: A. - Sind, 711-12; Ghazni, 963; Muizzuddin, 1173; Tarain, 1191.

Workbook MCQ 10

"Persianate" is best understood as:

- A. a synonym for Shia Islam
- B. a transregional sphere of Persian language, literature, court culture and administration
- C. proof of Iranian ethnicity
- D. a maritime trading corporation

Answer: B. -

Workbook MCQ 11

Improved communications between Ghazni, Kabul and Jalalabad would most directly:

- A. create monsoon winds
- B. unify all Rajput states
- C. improve movement, supply, intelligence and reinforcement
- D. eliminate the need for revenue

Answer: C. -

Workbook MCQ 12

A commercial diaspora is:

- A. a population cut off from all external ties
- B. an administration based only on Persian texts
- C. a conquering army settled on land grants
- D. a mobile merchant community retaining long-distance ties while creating local institutions

Answer: D. -

Workbook MCQ 13

Which concept best captures the movement of Indian astronomy into Arabic learning?

- A. Translation ecosystem
- B. Territorial annexation
- C. Feudatory militarisation
- D. Biological diffusion

Answer: A. - Translation involves patrons, scholars, languages, selection and adaptation.

Workbook MCQ 14

Why is "political vacuum" an unsafe description of north India after Pratihara decline?

- A. The Pratiharas continued unchanged until 1526.
- B. Regional successor states possessed political, agrarian and military capacity.
- C. No feudatories existed.
- D. The Cholas ruled every part of north India.

Answer: B. -

Workbook MCQ 15

What does the First Battle of Tarain, 1191, demonstrate most clearly for causal analysis?

- A. The Ghurids had no cavalry.
- B. Punjab returned permanently to the Hindu Shahis.
- C. Turkish political success was not inevitable.
- D. The Sultanate began in 1191.

Answer: C. -

Workbook MCQ 16

Which is the strongest explanation of the political transition?

- A. religion alone
- B. weapon type alone
- C. courage alone
- D. interaction of frontier change, mobility, concentrated command, rivalry and contingent decisions

Answer: D. -

Workbook MCQ 17

Consider the following statements:

1. Arab traders settled on the Malabar coast.
2. Indian merchants remained active around the Persian Gulf.
3. A port mosque necessarily proves foreign territorial sovereignty.

Which statements are correct?

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: A. - Statement 3 confuses community infrastructure with sovereignty.

Workbook MCQ 18

Which distinction is most useful when analysing Rajput military resources?

- A. fort versus temple patronage
- B. aggregate resources versus resources concentrated under unified command
- C. Hindu versus Muslim courage
- D. cavalry versus all other arms

Answer: B. -

Workbook MCQ 19

Rajputisation is most closely associated with:

- A. disappearance of Brahmanical legitimation
- B. a single migration in 1192
- C. interaction among agrarian expansion, political power and status formation
- D. replacement of agriculture by pastoralism

Answer: C. -

Workbook MCQ 20

Which statement most accurately treats cavalry advantage?

- A. Horses automatically defeat elephants.
- B. India had no mounted forces.
- C. Cavalry mattered only because of ethnicity.
- D. Mobility became decisive when integrated with command, remounts, intelligence and tactics.

Answer: D. -

Workbook MCQ 21

The Gahadavalas are associated principally with:

- A. Kannauj
- B. Malwa
- C. Ghazni
- D. Gujarat

Answer: A. -

Workbook MCQ 22

Which pair is correctly matched?

- A. Tomaras - Ghazni
- B. Chauhans - Ajmer
- C. Hindu Shahis - Chola maritime empire
- D. Paramaras - Malabar merchant settlement

Answer: B. -

Workbook MCQ 23

An excavated port and a named textual port should be identified with confidence only when:

- A. a popular tradition exists
- B. one imported object is found
- C. chronology, geography, stratigraphy and other evidence converge
- D. the modern names sound similar

Answer: C. -

Workbook MCQ 24

Why can the eighth-century Sind conquest not explain twelfth-century Ghurid expansion by itself?

- A. Ghazni had already fallen to Delhi.
- B. Sind had no trade.
- C. The Ghurids were Arab merchants.
- D. centuries, different actors and transformed West/Central Asian institutions intervened

Answer: D. -

Workbook MCQ 25

The International Spice Routes Conference of January 2026 is safest used in an answer as:

- A. a current example of maritime heritage, cultural corridors and heritage tourism
- B. an official archaeological report on medieval chronology
- C. proof that Arab traders ruled Kerala
- D. proof of the exact location of every ancient port

Answer: A. -

Workbook MCQ 26

Gyan Bharatam's digitisation programme can improve medieval research primarily by:

- A. proving every manuscript's claim
- B. expanding preservation, cataloguing and research access
- C. making later copies contemporary eyewitnesses
- D. removing the need for palaeography

Answer: B. -

Workbook MCQ 27

Which method is strongest for using a Persian court chronicle?

- A. reject it because it is elite
- B. accept its royal claims literally
- C. identify genre and patronage, then co-relate it with other evidence
- D. treat silence as proof of absence

Answer: C. -

Workbook MCQ 28

Which statement best distinguishes a raid from sustained expansion?

- A. A raid always changes sovereignty.
- B. Expansion never seeks revenue.
- C. A raid never uses cavalry.
- D. sustained expansion requires bases, garrisons, information and recurring revenue

Answer: D. -

Workbook MCQ 29

Which proposition best reflects the relationship between geography and conquest?

- A. Geography creates opportunities whose use depends on logistics and institutions.
- B. Frontier states cannot resist external pressure.
- C. A mountain pass automatically determines political control.
- D. Roads are irrelevant to cavalry.

Answer: A. -

Workbook MCQ 30

Why is “the Turks came only as destroyers” analytically inadequate?

- A. They rejected territorial rule.
- B. They also carried Persianate administrative, literary and political institutions.
- C. No conflict occurred.
- D. They were all merchants.

Answer: B. -

Workbook MCQ 31

Which framework produces the strongest causal answer?

- A. one decisive technology
- B. hero versus villain
- C. structural condition + institutional mechanism + contingent trigger
- D. civilisation versus civilisation

Answer: C. -

Workbook MCQ 32

The best final judgement on the initial Turkish breakthrough is:

- A. unrelated to frontier change
- B. predetermined by the conquest of Sind
- C. proof of universal Rajput military inferiority
- D. made more probable by structural shifts but realised through contingent political and military choices

Answer: D. -

Remedial correction MCQs

Remedial MCQ 01

Which correction best addresses the claim that Sind immediately created the Delhi Sultanate?

- A. Sind was a regional foothold and conduit; different actors and institutions produced the later Sultanate.
- B. The Ghaznavids conquered Sind in the eighth century.
- C. Arab maritime trade began only after 1206.
- D. Sind and Delhi were ruled continuously by one dynasty after 712.

Answer: A. The Arab conquest of Sind and the Ghurid-Sultanate transition were separated by centuries.

Remedial MCQ 02

What does Persianate most accurately describe in this context?

- A. Persian biological ancestry.
- B. A sphere of Persian language, court culture, literature and administration.
- C. Rejection of Islam by Turkish commanders.
- D. Replacement of every Indian language.

Answer: B. Persianisation was cultural and institutional, not an ethnic category.

Remedial MCQ 03

Which statement correctly defines iqta in the pre-Sultanate transition?

- A. A temple tax collected only at ports.
- B. Unrestricted hereditary ownership of cultivators.
- C. A ruler-controlled revenue assignment associated with service and troop maintenance.

- D. A Rajput clan council.

Answer: C. The assignment supported service obligations and did not automatically transfer full property rights.

Remedial MCQ 04

Which is the best correction to the claim that Rajput states had no resources?

- A. Their only weakness was inferior personal courage.
- B. They had no forts but controlled all cavalry imports.
- C. They formed a permanent all-India confederacy.
- D. Several had substantial revenue and armies, but durable inter-state coordination was difficult.

Answer: D. The central distinction is individual state capacity versus pooled command.

Remedial MCQ 05

Why is cavalry alone an insufficient explanation of Turkish success?

- A. Mobility worked through finance, logistics, intelligence, command and tactics.
- B. Infantry played no role in medieval warfare.
- C. Horses were absent from West and Central Asia.
- D. Every mounted army won every battle.

Answer: A. Military advantage was an organisational system rather than a single weapon.

Remedial MCQ 06

What can a permitted mosque in a merchant settlement establish most securely?

- A. Abolition of Indian Ocean trade.
- B. A resident community and local accommodation.
- C. Immediate foreign annexation.
- D. Uniform conversion of the surrounding population.

Answer: B. Religious infrastructure does not by itself prove transferred sovereignty.

Remedial MCQ 07

Why should the north-west not be described as an eternally open gate?

- A. Punjab was separated from Central Asia by the sea.
- B. No army crossed it before 1206.
- C. Routes became operational through political control, roads, bases, supply and intelligence.
- D. Geography had no strategic importance.

Answer: C. Terrain created opportunities and constraints that states had to organise.

Remedial MCQ 08

What is the correct use of digitised manuscripts in historical reconstruction?

- A. Digitisation proves every manuscript is contemporary with the event.
- B. Digital access removes genre and patronage bias.
- C. A repository replaces archaeological corroboration.
- D. Digitisation improves access, while dating, editing, translation and criticism remain necessary.

Answer: D. Access and evidentiary reliability are separate questions.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

I.1 Audit method

MAINS: read official GS-I papers, 2018-2025.

Search concepts:

Arab contact . Sind . Malabar . Turkish conquest . Ghazni . Hindu Shahi
Rajput political order . Persianisation . frontier . outer bastions . iqta

PRELIMS: inspect available GS-I papers, 2018-2026.

Retain only:

1. directly owned questions; or
2. application questions requiring this topic's chronology or institutions.

CLASSIFY:

OWNED = this topic is the question's central subject.

APPLICATION = another topic owns it, but this topic materially improves the answer.

INFERRED = relevant question solved from source-grounded subject knowledge because the official same-series key is unavailable; never represented as official.

I.2 Directly owned Mains result

FACT: **COUNT: ZERO** No GS-I Mains question from 2018-2025 directly asks the pre-Sultanate political setting, Indo-Arab maritime contact, Hindu Shahi frontier, Persianisation of Turkish elites or the causes of the initial Turkish breakthrough as its central subject. ANALYSIS: This is consistent with the official syllabus boundary: Medieval History is directly owned by Prelims, while Mains GS-I uses it chiefly through art, literature and architecture. The topic remains important because it supplies context for source, technology and culture questions.

I.3 Directly owned Prelims result

FACT: **COUNT: ZERO with a locally readable official same-series key** Several adjacent questions test chronology, iqta or early-medieval dynasties, but their true ownership lies in later administration or regional-kingdom topics. They are solved below as application items rather than force-fitted. Because their official same-series keys are unavailable locally, every answer is explicitly marked as inferred.

I.4 Solved Prelims application PYQs - inferred answers

P-1 · Prelims 2019 · revenue administration of the Delhi Sultanate

FACT: **Question:** Consider the following statements:

1. The in-charge of revenue collection was known as *amil*.
2. The iqta system was an ancient indigenous institution.
3. The office of *Mir Bakshi* came into existence under the Khaljis.

(a) 1 only (b) 1 and 2 only (c) 3 only (d) 1, 2 and 3

ANALYSIS: **True owner:** Sultanate administration, Topic 07. ANALYSIS: **Why relevant:** it tests the defining trap "iqta = indigenous/hereditary property".

ANALYSIS: **INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED: (a) 1 only · Confidence: High**

Elimination logic

- FACT: Statement 1 is correct: *amil* was associated with revenue assessment/collection at the local level under the Sultanate.
- WRONG: Statement 2 is incorrect: iqta was part of the wider Islamic-West/Central Asian revenue-service tradition, not an ancient indigenous institution.
- WRONG: Statement 3 is incorrect: *Mir Bakshi* is principally a Mughal central office, not an office created by the Khalji sultans.

CAUTION: **Provenance note:** the attempted official UPSC key URL returned an error page. The answer is therefore an expert historical inference, not an official-key claim.

P-2 · Prelims 2020 · chronology of Pallava, Pala, Pratihara and Chola power

FACT: **Question:** Consider the following events in the history of India:

1. Rise of the Pratiharas under Bhoja.
2. Establishment of Pallava power under Mahendravarman I.
3. Establishment of Chola power under Parantaka I.
4. Foundation of the Pala dynasty by Gopala.

(a) 2-1-4-3 (b) 3-1-4-2 (c) 2-4-1-3 (d) 3-4-1-2

ANALYSIS: **True owner:** Ancient/Early Medieval regional chronology. ANALYSIS: **Why relevant:** it establishes the political order preceding Topic 01.

ANALYSIS: **INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED: (c) 2-4-1-3 · Confidence: High**

Chronology

1. Mahendravarman I's Pallava power - early seventh century.
2. Gopala founds the Pala dynasty - mid-eighth century.
3. Bhoja's Pratihara ascendancy - ninth century.
4. Parantaka I's Chola reign - early tenth century.

CAUTION: **Provenance note:** the local official-key link was unreadable. The sequence is inferred from established dynastic chronology and externally cross-checked, but is not labelled official.

P-3 · Prelims 2022 · early-medieval kings and dynasties

FACT: **Question:** Consider the following pairs:

1. Nannuka - Chandela
2. Jayashakti - Paramara
3. Nagabhata II - Gurjara-Pratihara
4. Bhoja - Rashtrakuta

(a) Only one pair (b) Only two pairs (c) Only three pairs (d) All four pairs

ANALYSIS: **True owner:** Regional kingdoms, Topic 08. ANALYSIS: **Why relevant:** Chandellas and Pratiharas form part of the transition map.

ANALYSIS: **INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED: (b) Only two pairs · Confidence: High**

Pair-by-pair test

- FACT: Nannuka - Chandela: correct.
- WRONG: Jayashakti - Paramara: incorrect; Jayashakti belonged to the Chandela line.
- FACT: Nagabhata II - Gurjara-Pratihara: correct.
- WRONG: Bhoja - Rashtrakuta: incorrect in the intended pairing; Bhoja is associated with the Paramaras, while Mihira Bhoja belongs to the Gurjara-Pratiharas.

CAUTION: **Provenance note:** the attempted official key returned an error page. The answer is inferred from standard dynastic identification.

P-4 · Prelims 2023 · Hoysala, Gahadavala, Kakatiya and Yadava chronology

FACT: **Question:** Consider the following dynasties:

1. Hoysala
2. Gahadavala
3. Kakatiya
4. Yadava

How many of the above dynasties established their kingdoms in the early eighth century CE?

(a) Only one (b) Only two (c) Only three (d) None

ANALYSIS: **True owner:** Regional kingdoms, Topic 08. ANALYSIS: **Why relevant:** the Gahadavalas are a major “eve of conquest” power.

ANALYSIS: **INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED: (d) None · Confidence: High**

Elimination logic

- Hoysalas emerged substantially later than the early eighth century.
- Gahadavalas rose in the late eleventh century.
- Kakatiya power belongs to a later early-medieval/medieval phase.
- Seuna Yadava political prominence also belongs to a later phase.

CAUTION: **Provenance note:** no locally held official 2023 key was available. The answer is inferred from established chronology.

ANALYSIS: **Audit conclusion:** all four application PYQs are now solved rather than omitted. Their answers are high-confidence historical inferences and are visually separated from official-key verification. This preserves usefulness without misrepresenting provenance.

M-1 · 2018 · GS-I · 10 marks · 150 words

FACT: **Question:** “Assess the importance of the accounts of the Chinese and Arab travellers in the reconstruction of the history of India.”

ANALYSIS: **True owner:** Historical sources. ANALYSIS: **Topic 01 contribution:** Arab maritime circuits, outsider evidence and reconstruction of contact.

Demand decoding

- **Assess** requires a graded judgement, not a list of travellers.
- **Importance** requires comparison with other evidence.
- **Reconstruction** requires source criticism: what can the account establish, and what can it not?

Model answer

Chinese and Arab accounts are high-value external witnesses when tied to named contexts. **Xuanzang's seventh-century record** describes Harsha's political world, Nalanda and Buddhist geography; it reconstructs institutions and routes, although a pilgrim naturally magnified Buddhist centres. **Sulaiman and al-Masudi** noticed major north Indian and Deccan powers and commerce linking Indian ports to the Persian Gulf; this proves wide trade and political reputations, but some information came through merchants rather than direct travel. **Al-Biruni's Kitab-ul-Hind*** used Sanskrit learning to compare religion, astronomy and social classification; it is unusually analytical, yet its Brahmanical textual access and north-western setting narrowed its social range. Their itinerary, genre, language and audience must therefore be tested against inscriptions, coins, archaeology and Indian texts. They are indispensable corroborative evidence, not neutral photographs of all-India conditions.

Why this earns marks: It assesses rather than lists, integrates three named sources with what each proves and limits, and ends with a graded corroboration-based judgement suited to 10 marks.

What a top answer must contain

1. Source class, not traveller biography.
2. Arab accounts linked to maritime commerce.
3. At least three filters: itinerary, language, purpose, patron/audience.
4. Co-relation with material and Indian textual evidence.
5. A graded final judgement.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on “M-1 · 2018 · GS-I · 10 marks · 150 words”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 10-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise three named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “M-1 · 2018 · GS-I · 10 marks · 150 words”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

M-2 · 2020 · GS-I · 15 marks · 250 words

FACT: **Question:** “Persian literary sources of medieval India reflect the spirit of the age. Comment.”

ANALYSIS: **True owner:** Medieval literature and society. ANALYSIS: **Topic 01 contribution:** formation of the Persianate political-cultural sphere.

Demand decoding

“Comment” requires explanation plus qualification. “Spirit of the age” cannot be accepted as meaning the experience of every social group.

Model answer

Persian sources reflect the age because their different genres preserve both the ideals and tensions of medieval society. **Barani's Tarikh-i Firoz Shahi** chronicles Sultanate politics and measures such as *Alauddin Khalji's market regulations*, while his normative **Fatawa-i Jahandari** exposes aristocratic, orthodox and hierarchical ideals; together they reveal statecraft, but Barani's elite prejudice and didactic purpose require caution. **Abul Fazl's court-sponsored Akbarnama** legitimises Akbar's sovereignty, whereas the **Ain-i Akbari** systematises offices, revenue and imperial resources; they demonstrate bureaucratic ambition, but imperial patronage encourages an idealised image. Counter-voices broaden this picture. **Badauni's Muntakhab-ut-Tawarikh** records conservative opposition to Akbar's religious experiments, proving dissent within the court, though its hostility is also polemical. **Amir Khusrau's Khaza'in-ul-Futuh** (ornate prose panegyric) and **Tughluq-nama** (narrative verse) celebrate conquest and Indo-Persian encounter; court dependence and poetic licence limit literal use. **Gulbadan Begum's Humayun-nama**, a royal memoir commissioned under Akbar, reveals kinship, mobility and women's agency inside the Mughal household, but remains an elite-harem view. **The Fawa'id-ul-Fu'ad***, Amir Hasan Sijzi's record of Nizamuddin Auliya's discourses, shifts attention to the khanqah, urban anxieties and a wider devotional public; as disciple-compiled conversations rather than court history, it too is mediated. Thus Persian literature captures court, administration, dissent, domestic life and Sufi sociability-not the whole society. Its “spirit” becomes historically representative only through comparison across genres and corroboration with vernacular texts, inscriptions, coins, architecture and material evidence.

Why this earns marks: It comments through six genre-specific source clusters, links patronage and social reach to evidentiary limits, and gives a qualified verdict within a 15-mark scale.

What a top answer must contain

- Persianate ≠ ethnically Persian.
- Multiple genres and functions.
- Transregional and Indian adaptation.
- Patronage and elite bias.
- Co-relation and a qualified verdict.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on “M-2 · 2020 · GS-I · 15 marks · 250 words”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “M-2 · 2020 · GS-I · 15 marks · 250 words”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

M-3 · 2023 · GS-I · 15 marks · 250 words

FACT: Question: “What were the major technological changes introduced during the Sultanate period? How did those technological changes influence the Indian society?”

ANALYSIS: True owner: Sultanate administration, economy and society. **ANALYSIS: Topic 01 contribution:** cavalry, transregional circulation and institution-mediated adaptation.

Demand decoding

The question has two equal halves: identify changes and explain social influence. A device-list without mechanisms answers only half.

Model answer

The Sultanate accelerated the diffusion and recombination of technologies; it did not introduce every device to India for the first time. **The spinning wheel**, whose earliest Indian reference Satish Chandra places in the mid-fourteenth century, raised a spinner's efficiency several-fold; it enlarged yarn supply and textile markets, although spinning remained dispersed, gendered household labour. **Paper-making**, for which Indian manuscript evidence becomes available from the Sultanate centuries, made records and books cheaper to reproduce; it strengthened scribal administration and scholarship, but literacy remained socially restricted. **The Persian wheel and improved water-lifting devices** could extend irrigation and cultivation; they supported surplus where wells, capital and local control permitted, not uniformly across India. **Lime mortar with the true arch and dome**, visible in the scientifically constructed arches and dome of the Alai Darwaza, enabled larger durable structures; Indian masons adapted these forms, proving synthesis rather than the displacement of local craftsmanship. **Cavalry equipment, imported horses and road-post relays** increased military mobility and communication; they linked ports, frontier routes, treasury and army, but imposed high fiscal and import costs. The social influence was therefore institutional: courts purchased horses and commissioned buildings, revenue systems funded communications, and markets sustained paper-makers, weavers and masons. Technologies created new skills, urban demand and administrative reach, yet their benefits and burdens varied by region and class. The Sultanate's major contribution was accelerated circulation and Indian adaptation-neither total rupture nor unchanged continuity.

Why this earns marks: It answers both halves through five named technologies, explains a social mechanism and qualification for each, and avoids the inaccurate “first introduced” claim.

What a top answer must contain

- No “all technologies were first introduced” overclaim.
- Military, production, documentary and architectural categories.
- A mechanism for every social effect.
- Indian adaptation and artisan agency.
- Uneven consequences and balanced judgement.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on “M-3 · 2023 · GS-I · 15 marks · 250 words”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “M-3 · 2023 · GS-I · 15 marks · 250 words”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

O-1 (10 marks · 150 words)

Explain why the expression “India on the eve of the medieval age” should not be equated with a political vacuum.

Demand

Define the expression, establish existing capacity, identify change and conclude with a qualified transition.

Model answer

“On the eve” is an analytical snapshot of transition, not evidence that political institutions had vanished. The weakening of the **Pala-Pratihara-Rashtrakuta competitive order** redistributed power to **Gahadavalas, Chauhans, Paramaras, Chalukyas, Chandellas and Tomars**; their forts, agrarian revenue and armies prove regional state capacity, although authority was divided among sovereign centres. **Chola administration and maritime commerce in the south** further disprove an all-India vacuum, while also showing that north Indian fragmentation was regionally specific. The problem was collective rather than individual capacity. **The Chaulukya defeat of Muizzuddin in 1178-79 and Prithviraj's victory at Tarain in 1191** show that Indian powers could resist, but rival interests made durable common command difficult. At the same time, Hindu Shahi losses and a Punjab base moved organised Turkish states closer to the plains. The eve of the medieval transition was therefore a regionalised political order under altered frontier pressure. “Vacuum” conceals both strong successor states and the coordination problem that shaped their response.

Why this earns marks: It uses three evidence clusters to prove continuing capacity, identifies the precise weakness, and gives a qualified 10-mark verdict instead of narrating decline.

Top-answer checklist

- Regionalisation, not vacuum.
- Named states.
- Capacity versus coordination.
- Frontier transformation.
- Qualified judgement.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on “O-1 (10 marks · 150 words)”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 10-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise three named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “O-1 (10 marks · 150 words)”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

O-2 (10 marks · 150 words)

Differentiate Arab maritime contact from Turkish military penetration into India.

Model answer

Arab maritime contact was a long-duration commercial-cultural process; Turkish penetration was increasingly military-territorial. **Arab settlements in Malabar and Rashtrakuta permission for mosques** prove negotiated residence under Indian sovereignty, although coastal accommodation did not exclude occasional conflict. **Indian merchants, physicians and craftsmen around the Persian Gulf and Baghdad** show reciprocal exchange rather than Arab displacement; goods moved with numerals, astronomy and medicine. Turkish expansion operated through the north-west. **Ghazni's roads towards Kabul-Jalalabad and the later Punjab base** supported cavalry, supply and intelligence, turning contact into repeated campaigning and garrisoned control. These commanders were already Islamised and Persianised and carried revenue-service and courtly institutions, but frontier access did not ensure victory, as Muizzuddin's reverses in Gujarat and at Tarain show. Thus the sea route usually produced diaspora, trade and cultural transmission, whereas the land route increasingly changed sovereignty. They intersected, but conquest neither began all contact nor followed automatically from commerce.

Why this earns marks: It differentiates route, agents and political effect through three named evidence clusters and qualifies both processes within a 10-mark word scale.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on “O-2 (10 marks · 150 words)”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 10-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise three named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “O-2 (10 marks · 150 words)”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

O-3 (10 marks · 150 words)

What is meant by the Persianisation of Turkish elites, and why is it important for medieval Indian history?

Model answer

Persianisation was the adoption of Persian language, literature, court etiquette and administrative practice by Turkish military elites; it did not imply Persian ethnicity or abandonment of Islam. **Turkish commanders recruited in the Iranian-Transoxianan world after Abbasid fragmentation assimilated the dominant Iranian language and culture**; this proves that entrants into India already possessed a transregional political idiom, though their societies remained culturally mixed. Its importance was institutional. **Ghazni** joined cavalry command to a Persianate court and documentary kingship, showing that Turkish power was more than weaponry, although its early Indian reach was often raid- and tribute-based. **Iqta**, a revocable revenue-service assignment, helped sultans sustain mobile troops without granting hereditary landownership; it linked administration to military capacity, but evolved further under the Delhi Sultanate. Persianisation therefore supplied language, legitimacy and governing techniques that later interacted with Indian revenue systems, elites and artisans. Medieval transition was institutional recombination, not a simple clash of ethnic civilisations.

Why this earns marks: It defines the term, uses three named examples to show political consequences and limits, and directly explains significance in a 10-mark frame.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on “O-3 (10 marks · 150 words)”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 10-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise three named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “O-3 (10 marks · 150 words)”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

O-4 (15 marks · 250 words)

Assess the role of the north-western frontier in the establishment of Turkish rule in north India.

Model answer

The north-western frontier was not an eternally open gateway; it was a layered system of buffers, routes and bases. **Hindu Shahi control over Kabul, Jalalabad and adjoining zones** created strategic depth between Central Asian military states and Punjab; their losses around 990-91 reduced that depth, although resistance continued. **Ghaznavid road improvement towards Kabul and Jalalabad** converted terrain into supply, intelligence, reinforcement and retreat. **Punjab's incorporation as a forward base** then lowered the cost of repeated operations and improved local information. Frontier change enabled but did not determine conquest. **The Chaulukyas defeated Muizzuddin near Mount Abu in 1178-79**, proving that access through the frontier could be blocked by prepared regional power. **Prithviraj's victory at the First Battle of Tarain in 1191** similarly shows that battle outcomes depended on leadership and tactics. Even after success, Turkish forces could not retain distant **Anhilwara**, revealing the continuing constraint of operational distance. The frontier became decisive only when geography combined with mobile cavalry, revenue mobilisation, concentrated command and divisions among north Indian powers. The “outer bastions” thesis is therefore useful for explaining lost strategic depth, but anachronistic if treated as a fixed national boundary and deterministic if made a sufficient cause. Institutions and political choices converted routes into power.

Why this earns marks: It assesses frontier importance through six named examples, explains logistical mechanisms, and balances enabling structure with reverses and limits.

Top-answer checklist

- Buffers, roads and bases.
- Hindu Shahis and Punjab.
- Logistics mechanism.
- At least one contingency.
- “Enabling, not determining” verdict.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on “O-4 (15 marks · 250 words)”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “O-4 (15 marks · 250 words)”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

O-5 (15 marks · 250 words)

“The Rajput political order combined considerable strength with a severe coordination problem.” Discuss.

Model answer

The Rajput order combined substantial regional state capacity with weak collective strategy. **Gahadavalas, Chauhans, Paramaras, Chalukyas, Chandellas and Tomars** commanded agrarian revenue, forts, feudatories and military followings; their number proves regionalisation, not political vacuum, although resources were divided among sovereign centres. **The Chaulukya defeat of Muizzuddin near Mount Abu in 1178-79** and **Prithviraj's victory at the First Battle of Tarain in 1191** demonstrate effective resistance; neither courage nor battlefield capacity was absent. The central limitation was converting aggregate strength into durable common command. **Prithviraj's campaigns against neighbouring powers**, as Satish Chandra notes, left him politically isolated; regional ambition weakened diplomatic depth even when armies were large. **Gahadavala non-assistance during the struggle for the upper doab** further illustrates separate threat perceptions, though it should not be reduced to a timeless “Rajput disunity” stereotype. Feudatory contingents could mobilise locally but complicated unified reserves, intelligence and reinforcement. Rajput polities also adapted: coalitions formed, forts resisted and Turkish forces suffered reverses. Their problem was relational-opponents operating from Ghazni and Punjab could sometimes concentrate mobile forces and fiscal resources faster. The order was therefore strong in regional legitimacy and defence but limited in sustained inter-state coordination. Turkish victory reflected particular strategic asymmetries, not civilisational or moral inferiority.

Why this earns marks: It balances capacity and coordination through five named examples, rejects the bravery stereotype, and delivers an assessed rather than one-sided verdict.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on “O-5 (15 marks · 250 words)”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “O-5 (15 marks · 250 words)”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

O-6 (15 marks · 250 words)

How did commercial and intellectual exchanges prepare a cultural bridge between India and the Islamic world before Turkish political rule?

Model answer

Commercial and intellectual exchange created channels of familiarity long before Turkish sovereignty. **Arab settlements on the Malabar coast** show durable merchant diasporas under Indian rulers; **Rashtrakuta permission for mosques** proves negotiated religious space, but neither settlement nor worship implied foreign sovereignty. The network was reciprocal: **Indian merchants around the Persian Gulf and Indian physicians and craftsmen welcomed at Baghdad** demonstrate Indian agency rather than Arab displacement. Commerce also carried knowledge. **Sind after the Arab conquest transmitted Indian numerals and astronomical works such as the Surya Siddhanta into Arabic scholarly environments**; this proves translation across political frontiers, although knowledge was selected and transformed rather than transferred unchanged. **Lahore's growth as an Arabic-Persian centre and the poetry of Masud Sad Salman** show that north-western cities became cultural intermediaries before the Delhi Sultanate; their literary evidence, however, represents educated circles more than the whole population. The bridge did not abolish conflict. Sind was conquered, frontier warfare continued, and merchant accommodation did not equal mass conversion. Its importance was preparatory rather than deterministic: trade, migration, translation and resident communities supplied routes and institutions through which later Persianate political culture interacted with India. Conquest changed sovereignty, but did not initiate Indo-Islamic contact.

Why this earns marks: It integrates five precise examples across commerce, migration and scholarship, explains what each proves, and qualifies “cultural bridge” against peaceful-contact romanticism.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on “O-6 (15 marks · 250 words)”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim → evidence → inference → qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “O-6 (15 marks · 250 words)”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

O-7 (15 marks · 250 words)

Explain how cavalry mobility, revenue organisation and command interacted in the Turkish military advantage.

Model answer

Cavalry superiority was an organisational system, not a racial or weapon-based attribute. **Ghaznavid roads linking Ghazni with Kabul and Jalalabad**, followed by a Punjab base, reduced operational friction; they enabled remounts, supply, intelligence and retreat, although difficult terrain still constrained campaigns. **At the Second Battle of Tarain, light mounted archers harassed Prithviraj's slower-moving force from several directions**; this proves manoeuvre and coordinated wings mattered, but the earlier Rajput victory in 1191 shows cavalry did not predetermine outcomes. Revenue made mobility sustainable. **Iqta gave an assignee the right to collect state revenue in return for maintaining troops, without hereditary ownership over land or cultivators**; it converted surplus into deployable force, although its mature Delhi Sultanate form evolved after the initial breakthrough. **Horse-import circuits through western ports and Central Asian routes** supported mounted warfare but also made it costly and dependent on trade. Command integrated these assets. **Prithviraj's politically isolated coalition and separate feudatory contingents** could possess large aggregate resources yet face delays in concentration and reinforcement. A Turkish ruler able to coordinate reserves, reconnaissance and pursuit could exploit that gap. Thus horses without finance were unsustainable, revenue without command remained dispersed, and command without roads lacked speed. The advantage arose from interaction among mobility, fiscal support and concentrated leadership, not cavalry technology alone.

Why this earns marks: It links five named examples into a mechanism, includes Tarain counter-evidence, and explains the interaction demanded rather than listing military features.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on “O-7 (15 marks · 250 words)”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “O-7 (15 marks · 250 words)”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

O-8 (20 marks · 300-350 words)

The establishment of Turkish rule in north India was a structural possibility, not a historical inevitability. Critically examine.

Model answer

By the late tenth to twelfth centuries, structures increased the possibility of Turkish expansion without making it inevitable. **Abbasid fragmentation produced regional military states whose Turkish commanders were Islamised and Persianised**; this joined cavalry command to Iranian court and administrative practices, but these states also fought and lost against rivals. **Hindu Shahi losses around Kabul and Jalalabad** reduced north India's strategic depth, while **Ghaznavid roads and a Punjab base** lowered the cost of supply, intelligence and repeated operations. Institutions converted opportunity into force. **Iqta linked revocable revenue assignments to troop maintenance**, allowing rulers to concentrate resources without conceding hereditary landownership; its exact Indian form, however, developed over time. North India was not a vacuum: **Gahadavalas, Chauhans, Chalukyas and Chandellas** possessed forts, agrarian revenue and armies. Their limitation was that separate strategic interests and feudatory command made collective reinforcement less reliable. Counter-evidence disproves inevitability. **The Chaulukyas defeated Muizzuddin near Mount Abu in 1178-79**, forcing him to shift his approach towards Punjab. **Prithviraj defeated him at the First Battle of Tarain in 1191**; the reversal in 1192 therefore reflects learning, preparation and tactical choice, not a predetermined civilisational outcome. Even after battlefield success, Turkish power could not retain distant **Anhilwara**, showing that bases and garrisons still bounded expansion. **Hasan Nizami's narrative and coins bearing Prithviraj's name with “Sri Muhammad Sam”** indicate an initial attempt to govern Ajmer through subordinate local authority; this proves conquest still required accommodation, although the sequence is source-dependent. Plunder and the **ghazi** idiom aided mobilisation, but neither explains variation in outcomes. Nor can horse technology explain success without roads, finance and command. Turkish rule was a **structural possibility** created by altered frontier depth, military-fiscal concentration and regional rivalry; it became reality through contingent leadership, diplomacy and battlefield adaptation. Structures changed the odds, while actors decided how those odds were realised.

Why this earns marks: It critically integrates eight named examples, tests the thesis with reverses and post-conquest limits, and produces a reasoned probability-not-inevitability verdict.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on “O-8 (20 marks · 300-350 words)”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 20-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise six to eight named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “O-8 (20 marks · 300-350 words)”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

O-9 (20 marks · 300-350 words)

Compare Arab maritime integration and Turkish military penetration as two distinct routes through which India became connected with West and Central Asia.

Model answer

Arab maritime integration and Turkish military penetration connected India to West and Central Asia through different routes, agents and institutions. **The maritime route was commercial and diasporic.** Arab settlements in Malabar operated under Indian rulers, and **Rashtrakuta permission for mosques** proves negotiated religious space without loss of sovereignty. **Indian merchants, physicians and craftsmen around the Persian Gulf and at Baghdad** show reciprocal mobility, not foreign displacement. **Sind's transmission of Indian numerals and astronomical learning into Arabic scholarship** demonstrates that ports and frontier towns moved knowledge as well as goods; however, the Arab conquest of Sind remained a regional political episode and did not mechanically create the Sultanate. **Sulaiman and al-Masudi's notices of Indian kingdoms and commerce** independently illuminate the reputation of these maritime circuits; they corroborate connectivity, but merchant testimony and outsider categories limit their social depth. **The land route was increasingly military-territorial.** **Hindu Shahi losses around Kabul and Jalalabad**, followed by Ghaznavid road improvement and a **Punjab forward base**, reduced the logistical distance to the plains. **Iqta-based revenue-service organisation** helped rulers maintain mobile troops and concentrated command, though its institutional form changed in India. The agents were sultans, commanders and cavalry rather than primarily merchant communities, and the immediate effects included tribute, garrisons and sovereignty. The routes nevertheless intersected. Lahore's Arabic-Persian learning and later **Amir Khusrau's Indian Persian literary culture** show that political centres entered older circuits of exchange. Conversely, the Muslim merchant colony encountered by Malik Kafur's army in the far south demonstrates that maritime communities persisted independently of northern conquest. Persianate institutions were further reshaped by Indian revenue practice, artisans, languages and local elites. Neither process should be romanticised: trade could carry hierarchy and conflict, while conquest could generate cultural synthesis. Court and travel texts also privilege literate, mobile groups over cultivators and local vernacular worlds. Together the routes show a connected medieval history in which the sea produced long-duration exchange and the north-western frontier concentrated political transformation.

Why this earns marks: It compares routes through seven integrated examples, explains interaction without collapsing trade into conquest, and gives a balanced 20-mark synthesis.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on “O-9 (20 marks · 300-350 words)”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 20-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise six to eight named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “O-9 (20 marks · 300-350 words)”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

O-10 (20 marks · 300-350 words)

“Organisation, not weapons; coordination, not courage; probability, not inevitability.” Use this proposition to explain the Turkish breakthrough in north India.

Model answer

The proposition corrects three monocausal explanations of the Turkish breakthrough. **Organisation, not weapons: At the Second Battle of Tarain, light mounted archers harassed Prithviraj's slower force from several directions**; this proves manoeuvre, reserves and command mattered more than horses alone.

Ghazni-Kabul-Jalalabad roads and a Punjab base sustained supply, intelligence and retreat, while **iqta revenue-service assignments** converted surplus into maintained troops. Yet Muizzuddin's **1178-79 defeat in Gujarat** shows that the same broad military culture could fail without favourable strategy and logistics.

Coordination, not courage: The Chaulukya victory and Prithviraj's First Tarain victory in 1191 demonstrate Rajput fighting capacity. The weakness was pooling multiple sovereign resources. **Prithviraj's expansion had isolated him politically**, and separate feudatory commands complicated reserves and reinforcement. This was not permanent incapacity-coalitions did form-but concentrated Turkish command could exploit delays in particular campaigns. **Probability, not inevitability: Hindu Shahi losses around Kabul and Jalalabad** reduced strategic depth and raised the probability of repeated penetration. Nevertheless, the reversal between Tarain 1191 and 1192 proves that preparation, leadership and tactical adaptation altered outcomes. Turkish inability to retain distant **Anhilwara** further shows that victory did not erase logistical limits. Durable sovereignty still required garrisons, revenue and accommodation with local elites. **Hasan Nizami's account and the "Sri Muhammad Sam" coins issued with Prithviraj's name** suggest that Ajmer was first managed through subordinate local rule; this proves political consolidation required accommodation after battle, although textual and numismatic evidence must be read together. Likewise, the **ghazi** language could legitimise mobilisation, but it cannot explain why Muslim Turkish states also lost to non-Muslim opponents or why campaigns succeeded unevenly. Religion, plunder, geography and technology contributed, but none independently explains changing results. The strongest chain is **condition**-frontier change and regional rivalry; **mechanism**-mobility, finance and unified command; and **trigger**-diplomacy, leadership and battlefield choice. The breakthrough was a contingent organisational success, not proof of civilisational superiority or foreordained collapse.

Why this earns marks: It structures the response around the quotation, integrates eight named evidence points and counter-cases, and ends with a causal rather than moral explanation.

1. Define the process before narrating events.
2. Separate chronology from causation.
3. Name actors precisely: Arab merchant, Turkish commander, Persianate court, Rajput polity.
4. Use geography through mechanisms: route, base, supply and intelligence.
5. Distinguish aggregate resources from concentrated resources.
6. Avoid bravery, race and civilisation stereotypes.
7. For technology, explain institution and social effect.
8. Include evidence against your own thesis.
9. Use "enabled", "increased probability" and "mediated", not "automatically caused".
10. End with a comparative, graded judgement.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on "O-10 (20 marks · 300-350 words)", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 20-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise six to eight named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "O-10 (20 marks · 300-350 words)", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.